

The Coastal California Fall Planting Quick List

Fall is the second spring here. In zones 9b and 10a, August through October is prime planting for everything that hates summer heat, and mild winters carry those crops clear to spring. The catch is the deadlines: days shorten fast, and a crop sown two weeks late can stall at half size until February. Watch the last-call dates.

August: the door opens

- **Direct sow:** lettuce, carrots, beets, radishes, kale, spinach, broccoli, and cabbage. Warm soil means fast, even germination; shade new sowings through heat spells.
- **Transplant:** kale, broccoli, and cauliflower starts go out now through September.
- **Start indoors:** lettuce for transplanting in September and October.
- **Strawberries:** the coastal planting window opens; set out transplants now through November for spring fruit.

September: the big month, and the first deadlines

- **Direct sow:** peas (through November), spinach, radishes, beets, lettuce, kale, and cilantro, which finally stops bolting.
- **Transplant:** broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage, and lettuce starts.
- **Last call:** carrots and direct-sown broccoli. Sown after September, they crawl.
- **Last call:** broccoli and cauliflower transplants by the end of the month, so heads form before the shortest days.
- **Start indoors:** onion seed, September to October, for transplanting in late fall.

October: garlic month

- **Plant:** garlic cloves, October through December. The single best thing to plant this month.
- **Plant:** onion sets and seedlings, now through January.
- **Direct sow:** peas, spinach, radishes, and one more round of lettuce.
- **Last call:** lettuce and cabbage transplants. Later settings sit small until the days lengthen.
- **Herbs:** transplant parsley through November; sow cilantro anytime this month.
- **Strawberries:** keep planting; October and November settings root through winter and hit spring running.

What not to plant now

- **Tomatoes, peppers, squash, cucumbers, beans, and corn.** Fall warmth fools people; shortening days do not. These wait for late winter seed trays and spring soil.
- **Bare-root berries and fruit trees.** Close, but not yet. Their season is December through February, when nurseries stock dormant plants.

The three fall rules

1. Sooner beats later. Every week of delay past Labor Day costs real growth.
2. Water new sowings like it is still summer, because in September it is.
3. If you miss a window, skip to the next crop, not a late version of the old one. Garlic forgives October; broccoli does not.

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